need to recognize the trial and error that is required of any successful policy process. We start on a journey, and improve things based on criticism and empirical evidence. Bona fide errors are an integral part of any sound policy process. A policymaker who is not making mistakes is not trying hard enough.

It is better for the policymaker to honestly depict the lack of knowledge, to speak openly about all policymaking as a research process, and to embrace the process of crossing the river by feeling the stones.

A policy process that makes mistakes and learns from them

When we insist that no mistakes were made, the process of learning stops. Wherever humanly possible, new policy initiatives should first be rolled out on a small experimental basis. This will create experience based on which we can make more rational moves in the future. And, if something does not work too well, we can back away from it without having suffered too high a cost.

This is connected to an open and participatory process. If the policymaker claims to know how to cross the river, there is the danger of mistakes or inaction. If, on the other hand, the policymaker only claims to know how to feel the stones, and approaches the larger community with a sense of humility, this gives an environment that is more conducive to taking risks, learning from mistakes, and refining policy strategies based on evidence.

The capability of the policy community is a resource, that needs to be nurtured. An approach of acknowledging the uncertainties, and discussing and drawing lessons from failure is the key to obtaining improvements in the capability of the policy community over time. [1]